FROM THE

EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

On September 1, Mohan Bhagwat, the chief of the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS), made a statement in Guwahati that got less play than what followed. He called upon the people of the country to stop using the name 'India' and switch to 'Bharat'. No one may have noticed because it was hardly a novel remark. Right from its inception nearly a century ago, the RSS has made no secret of its preference. But even some of its adherents may have been surprised at the alacrity with which the Modi government took the cue. Two days later, a formal dinner invite from the Rashtrapati Bhavan to G20 guests described Droupadi Murmu as the 'President of Bharat'. Then, at the summit events, Prime Minister Narendra Modi very conspicuously sat behind a placard that read 'Bharat' instead of 'India'. Though no official announcement was made, the government was clearly intent on reviving an old debate about India's name, that too at a global public event. Rumours soon swirled around that the special Parliament session called on September 18-22, for unstated reasons, would see a bill to erase 'India' from the formal nomenclature. Opinions filled the air, with the Opposition calling it a diversionary tactic. A full-blown controversy had crept into the public discourse.

India or Bharat? There are cogent arguments for both. For our readers to get a better understanding, what we have done in this issue is to present a set of columns from eminent writers who set out views from across the gamut of political positions and historical interpretations. It's akin to the ancient Buddhist parable of seven blind men and an elephant: an attempt to present the truth in all its totality.



The question could have become a cantankerous debate right upon the birth of the modern republic. Both 'India' and 'Bharat' have a long genealogy spanning millennia, and both had strong adherents at that formative time. But the Constitution-makers, in their wisdom, resorted to an ingenious formula to settle the question peacefully. Article 1 of the Constitution starts with an equation: "India, that is Bharat...." What they abolished with that was the idea of one being 'versus' the other. Instead of seeing it as an either/or question, they decided that there was space for both realities to coexist. Both names were deemed acceptable and were granted equal status. 'India', being the one used and recognised universally, within India and far beyond, was not discarded. Nor was 'Bharat'.

This judicious way of thinking was in line with the ethos that had always governed this civilisation. Interestingly, a reflection of that comes through even in columns from opposite sides of the fence in this issue. As a brief backgrounder, the BJP and those close to it feel 'Bharat' is a more appropriate choice because it is a native name with a great deal of antiquity, going back to the Vedas. The economist Sanjeev Sanyal, whose popular writings on history lean towards the conservative right, captures that argument in his column—referencing the famous Rigvedic story of the Battle of the Ten Kings that the 'Bharata' clan fought. But as he writes, even the gradual adoption of that name for a larger entity rested on a process of accommodation of multiple tribes and their gods. Not imposition or conquest. 'India', according to this view, is a name that is less preferable because foreigners gave it to us.

Those who disagree with this line of thinking point to an essential flaw in that preference. Congress MP Shashi Tharoor explains it with his usual elan. 'India' has as much antiquity and derives from the original name of the Indus river—Sindhu—via the Persian rendition. And if that route makes it illegitimate, it would also debar other proper nouns like 'Hindu', which derive from the same etymology. Moreover, unlike 'Bharat', it does not sound like an explicitly Hindi word—Indian languages that adopted the name during the freedom struggle render it in variations such as 'Bharatham'. But Tharoor, too, harks back to the Constitution to write: "Reconciling irreconcilables is a great Indian virtue."

Other columnists open up many layers of questions. The law expert Arvind P. Datar tells us how the historical elements informed the choice of the Constitution-makers. Former diplomat Pavan K. Varma reveals a few delicious nuggets while citing the stability 'India' has had historically across the globe. Historian G. Arunima provides a Southern perspective, revealing the first Malayalam use of 'India' in an 18th century travelogue, with 'Bharat' popping up only two centuries later. Dalit scholar Kancha Ilaiah Shepherd writes why the very Vedic/ Pauranic basis of 'Bharat' and its Kshatriya source-myths make it problematic for the vast majority of Indians, from the non-privileged castes and other religions. 'India', he writes, is by definition more neutral and inclusive, besides reflecting the depth of the country's pre-Aryan legacy from the Harappan times. Academic Ravinder Kaur, who has authored a book on the role 'branding' has played in the evolution of contemporary India, examines the consequences of a name-change. Film critic Baradwaj Rangan takes a light-hearted look at one of the most unifying cultural streams of modern times, the cinema, and sees a conflation of India, Hind/ Hindustani and Bharat. And Seshadri Chari brings the RSS perspective forcefully.

The other big issue is the timing. Critics say that if renaming the country was a matter of utter urgency, the BJP would have done it during A.B. Vajpayee's tenure or when PM Modi took office in 2014. That it chose this late hour leaves open the conclusion that it had something to do with the Opposition alliance naming itself 'INDIA' and the fact that five state elections are just weeks away and it could be a handy distraction.

The rich cultural diversity of India/ Bharat is one of our greatest assets, spectacularly showcased to the world in the recent G20. We pray to many gods, converse in many languages and tolerance coupled with accommodation is part of our ethos. Several countries have different nomenclatures. Japan is also Nippon. The United Kingdom is often referred to as Great Britain, not to speak of the near-equivalence we give to 'England'. Perhaps, the India/ Bharat controversy is much ado about nothing. I say, take your pick—Bharat or India—and let's move on. We have many more serious issues that affect the lives of Indians/ Bharatiyas.



(Aroon Purie)

Last week, one of our dearest former colleagues, the cartoonist Ajit Ninan, passed away. With his wicked and subtle humour, he adorned these pages for 16 years. His passing is a great loss to Indian journalism. I will also miss him as a human being.

Illustration by NILANJAN DAS